– conscientious on the top, stagnant at the middle and sociopathic underneath, who will do anything to glorify themselves in the eyes of an unsuspecting public. So, you ask, what sort of man does this? A desperate one, we might say, or a small one, indeed, or an archdeacon who had spent the night on the streets, ‘sleeping with panthers’, as Oscar Wilde said, only to arrive at his office in the morning and issue a brutal diktat against panthers. The young staff on his paper might blush at his methods, seeing how fast Mr Keller could turn from hungry collaborator to ungrateful avenger in the time it takes to speed-dial the White House.

But you know how it is: part of you is loath to face the fact that a promising working relationship is dead. It’s dead now, but at the time I was still, however inexpertly, trying to keep the cartel together to work on as-yet-unpublished documents. Again, I was focused on the work itself: it seemed imperative to get the material out and make it available to researchers and readers. I hadn’t gone into this game to store up papers. I wanted to release them, however gradually, so that they would make the impact they ought to have had. In the event, we just muddled through, and I worked with some TV people at the same time on shaping a couple of documentaries to stoke public interest.

The relationship with the newspapers would get more explosive in the coming weeks, and I’ll come to that. But let’s not lose sight, in all of this, of the leaks themselves. Together, the Afghan and Iraq war logs are a major historical record, and they will not be bossed off the page by squabbling tribes. In some ways, they were the culmination of years of thinking, on my part and on the part of my colleagues, about how to open up the secret worlds that so define our lives and our global politics. For some people, they were just a passing story. But they will live with us now for as long as we are interested in the vicissitudes of human conflict. Let us enter into them and see what is there, before returning to the indignant soap opera of the modern media.